

Fantasy City Expansion: Violets & Stone

(Fate's Edge v1.0)

A plug-and-play urban module for Fate's Edge campaigns set among bridges, aqueducts, rites, caravans, and crown politics.

DESIGN GOALS

- **City as character.** Districts and institutions carry tags, Strings, and timers that push back.
 - **Plug into core.** Use Position/DV, SB, and timers; no new dice math.
 - **Street to state.** Blend casework, capers, and civic settlements.
 - **Low bookkeeping.** Track names and tags; let timers and Strings carry weight.
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QUICKSTART (2 MINUTES)

1. Pick a City Kit (§7). Set Mandate 2 / Crisis 2 unless fiction says otherwise.
2. Choose 4 Factions from the kit; copy their Strings; start each faction's Influence or Agenda timer at 0.
3. Mark 2 volatile stakes on the relationship map (e.g., "Harbor Master owes Corsairs a favor").
4. Draw the Urban Deck (§6.2): one Incident (Spade), one Person (Heart), one Complication (Club) to spark the opening dilemma.
5. Frame the first Situation Timer [4–8] and at least one Counter-Timer [4–6].
6. Play scenes. All 1s generate SB; spend city-flavored Social SB (optional, see §3.4).

Pro Tip: Start with the Three-Timer Rule – only track the Situation Timer, one Counter-Clock, and one Campaign Timer at a time.

1) CITY SHEET (TEMPLATE)

[CITY NAME]

Mandate (0–6): public legitimacy of the company in this city

Crisis (0–6): ambient pressure (riots, audits, plague, war drums)

Districts (5–8): each with tags & a District Effect (see §2)

Institutions (3–6): councils, courts, guilds, rites; each has Strings

Factions (4–8): playset; use Influence / Stability / Exposure timers (see §7)

Relationship Map: arrows with stakes; mark two volatile

Rites & Laws: 1–2 citywide oaths, bans, or permissions that change Position

Chase Modes: foot, canal, rooftops, alleyways (see §5)

Events: festival/omen/weather tables (see §6.3)

District Effect (per scene)

Acting with a district's tags → Position +1 or DV -1 once/scene. Acting against a district's tags → Position -1 or GM banks +1 SB. Whenever a player rolls a 1 in a district, the GM may tick that district's Complication timer (if any) by 1.

2) DISTRICT TAGS & EFFECTS (CHOOSE 6–8 COMMON)

- **Harbor & Quays** – brackish, fog, bribes, cranes
Effect: +1 Position for Smuggle/Survey; -1 Position for Sanctify/Expose.
Complication timer: *Docksider Rumors* [4].
 - **Market Ward** – hucksters, scales, guild seals
Effect: DV -1 for Broker/Petition with writs; +1 SB on Infiltrate (watchful).
Complication timer: *Guild Audit* [6].
 - **Temple Quarter** – bells, incense, oaths
Effect: Shield/Host Rite start Dominant; Bribe starts Desperate.
Complication timer: *Heresy Inquiry* [6].
 - **Scholars' Quarter** – scriptoriums, apprentices, disputes
Effect: Research/Expose DV -1 with proof; Blackmail Position -1 (they lawyer up).
Complication timer: *Scholastic Feud* [4].
 - **Underways & Sewers** – echo, mildew, sigils, smugglers
Effect: Infiltrate DV -1; on any 1, start *Sewer Folk* [4] or *Wards Stir* [6] timer.
Complication timer: *Flood Surge* [6].
 - **Legion/Watch Barracks** – drill, pennons, billets
Effect: Petition (order) starts Dominant; Expose starts Desperate.
Complication timer: *Curfew* [6].
 - **Bridges & Canals** – mossy stone, toll bells
Effect: Chase (boat/rooftop) DV -1; Broker worsens if tolls unpaid.
Complication timer: *Bridge-Lord's Grievance* [4].
 - **Patrician Heights** – courtyards, old blood
Effect: Petition DV -1 with Standing; otherwise Blackmail gains +1 SB.
Complication timer: *Duel Escalation* [4].
 - **Foundries & Yards** – smoke, sparks, strikes
Effect: Intimidate/Strike-bust Position +1; Host Feast Position -1.
Complication timer: *Rolling Strike* [6].
 - **Bazaars & Caravanserais** – spices, dialects, caravan law
Effect: Broker (trade) DV -1; Expose Position -1 (outsider loyalties).
Complication timer: *Caravan Feud* [4].
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3) CITY PROCEDURES

3.1 Scene Framing

State the question; pick a Situation Timer ; set Position & DV from fiction + district effect; start a Counter-Timer if opposition is active; tag the venue (Audience/Institution).

3.2 Strings (Urban)

Common Strings: Bridge Tolls, Aqueduct Permits, Ferry Passbooks, Oath-Tablet Registry, Harbor Pilots, Festival Licenses, Censor's Seal, Ship Papers, Privateer Charters, Contraband Manifests.

Acting with/through a relevant String: Position +1 or DV -1 once/scene. To cut or seize a String, start a 4-6 segment timer. On completion, you may:

- **Seize:** Gain control of the String for your own use.
- **Destroy:** Prevent anyone from using it.
- **Redirect:** Change who controls it (e.g., assign to a different faction).

Example: Cutting the String *Harbor Warrants* [4] – on success, you either obtain legitimate papers or prevent the harbor from issuing warrants against you.

3.3 City Dials (Mandate & Crisis)

- **Mandate (0-6)** – public legitimacy. At 4-5, cancel one Social SB in public venues once/session; public offices DV -1. At 6, start public scenes Dominant unless fiction forbids.
- **Crisis (0-6)** – ambient pressure. At 4-5, first failed public scene ticks party Exposure +1; at 6, start with a crowd Counter-Timer [4].

At the end of each session, if total SB spent by the GM exceeds 10, increase Crisis by 1. If the party successfully resolved 2+ major timers, increase Mandate by 1.

3.4 Social SB Menu (optional, city-flavored)

Instead of the generic SB menu (noise, alarm, etc.), GMs may choose from these urban complications:

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|--|--------------------|
| • Faux pas title/ritual | • Festival crush |
| • Lose 1 Favor in venue | • Toll chain drops |
| • Leverage leak → Exposure +1 | • Ship quarantine |
| • Crowd turns (Warm→Skeptical→Hostile) | • Cargo inspection |
| • Permit pulled (lose String access) | • Guild audit |
| • Patrol arrives biased | • Noble scandal |

- Temple censure
- Watch curfew
- Harbor closure
- Price fixing
- Counterfeit goods
- Debt collector
- Bounty hunter
- Informer betrayal
- Rival sabotage

3.5 Investigation Timer Management

For long-term mysteries, use an **Investigation Timer** [6]. Each significant clue advances the timer by:

- Clue Grade D or C $\rightarrow +1$
- Clue Grade B or A $\rightarrow +2$
- Clue Grade A+ $\rightarrow +3$

When the timer fills, the GM describes the complete truth – but also introduces a new complication (e.g., the culprit escapes, evidence is destroyed, or a powerful figure is implicated).

Example progression: Clue D (1) $\rightarrow$ Clue C (1) $\rightarrow$ Clue B (2) $\rightarrow$ Clue A+ (3) = 7 segments $\rightarrow$ truth revealed, but the villain has already fled.

3.6 Between-Session Cycle

Update world state $\rightarrow$ draw events (§6.3) $\rightarrow$ resolve off-screen orders $\rightarrow$ recompute Mandate/Crisis $\rightarrow$ prep next Situation.

4) URBAN ACTIONS (ADDITIONS)

- **Invoke Rite (Wits/Presence + Rite):** Claim hospitality, sanctuary, or festival privilege. Hit: protective tag; miss: Exposure +1.
- **Grease Palms (Wits + Streetwise):** Secure permits/tolls. Hit: tag *Greased Palms*; miss: rumor of bribery (Exposure +1).
- **Audit Ledger (Wits + Investigation):** Catch graft/tithe anomalies. Hit: DV -1 on later Expose.
- **Call the Watch (Presence + Command):** Leverage order. Hit: *Watchful Patrols* tag; miss: they arrive biased.
- **Smuggle (Wits + Subterfuge):** Move goods/people across wards. Hit: gain Leverage (1) or fill; 1s start *Contraband Trail* timer.

- **Carouse for Rumors (Presence + Performance):** Trade coin and stories. Hit: bank 1 Clue (see §6.1); miss: SB → Hangover Debts.
- **Forge Documents (Wits + Tinker):** Create false papers/permits. Hit: tag *Forged Papers*; miss: Exposure +1.
- **Navigate Politics (Presence + Command):** Maneuver through civic structures. Hit: DV -1 on next Petition; miss: political rival gains Influence.
- **Bribe Official (Wits + Sway):** Pay for favors/permissions. Hit: tag *Bribe Accepted*; miss: Exposure +1.
- **Commission Contract (Presence + Broker):** Hire services/mercenaries. Hit: tag *Contract Secured*; miss: Exposure +1.

5) CHASES IN TIGHT STREETS (DV LADDERS)

Pick a mode; on a hit, advance Pursuit (or Escape) timer by Effect (1–3).

Mode	DV 2	DV 3	DV 4	DV 5
Foot	market	alleys	rooftops	through procession
Boat/Canal	open run	under bridges	against tide	fog storm
Mount/Cart	quay road	wagon traffic	stair-streets	temple steps
Ship-to-Ship	calm waters	choppy seas	storm winds	naval battle

Complications (on 1s): overturned barrow, toll chain drops, lantern goes out, festival throng, rigging tangles, hull breach, powder keg, enemy boarding party, reef strike, sudden fog, cargo shift, crew mutiny.

6) URBAN GENERATORS

6.1 Clues & Casework

Grades: A+ (witnessed oath; sealed writ) A (signed testimony; verified mark) B (two-source rumor; ledger trail) C (hearsay; graffiti) D (single rumor) F (planted tale; forged writ)

A day without follow-up degrades one step if contested. Spend: 1 Clue → DV -1 on a related Expose/Petition once.

6.2 Urban Deck (52-card)

Draw one card for each of Spade (Incident), Heart (Person), Club (Complication), Diamond (Boons/Resolution). **Timer size** by highest rank: 2–5 → [4], 6–10 → [6], J/Q/K → [8], A → [10].

Spades – Incidents

ritual misfire • theft of a writ • bridge collapse • missing tax barge • assassin in procession • cursed play • guild strike • seditious broadsheet • shrine desecration • plague rumor • treason trial • flood omen • **Ace:** cover for a coup.

Hearts – Persons

harbormaster • guild factor • inquisitor • bridge-lord • mummer • tribune • ferry pilot • matron • archivist • street saint • exile heir • quartermaster • **Ace:** a most trusted patron is complicit.

Clubs – Complications

curfew • festival crush • foreign immunities • taboo ground • closed shop • informant vanishes • watch obstruction • blackmail • riot brewing • double agent • cursed weather • **Ace:** solving it ruins someone you love.

Diamonds – Boons/Resolution

sealed archive • tariff exemption • festival license • street mandate • protection writ • house favor • council seat • tithe forgiving • pardon • endowment • patrol command • treasury award • **Ace:** The Truth, at public cost.

6.3 Events, Omens, Weather

Festivals:

- Boat Blessing
- New Charter Day
- Founders' Procession
- Lantern Vigil
- Moon Market
- Salt Blessing
- Ship Launch
- Merchant's Fair
- Sailor's Wake
- Governor's Ball
- Execution Day
- Tax Collection

Omens:

- blood tide
- comet
- cracked idol
- whisper-plague
- augur's scandal
- ship's bell tolling
- raven's call
- broken mast
- cursed cargo
- ghost ship sighted
- temple weeping
- market crash

Weather:

- fog bank
- heat wave
- black rain
- river in spate
- winter of knives
- sudden storm
- red sky
- calm seas
- waterspout
- ice floes
- sandstorm
- hurricane winds

7) CITY KITS (PLAYSETS)

Each kit includes 4 factions with their Aim, Strings, and starting timers. Faction timers (e.g., *Influence [6/]*) tick when they achieve their Aim; when full, they make a major move.

7.1 Mid Ahkaz – Ykrul Trade Capital

Districts: Violet Bazaar; Steppe Gate; Satrap Gardens; Coin-Weigh House; Under-Arcades; Caravan Rings. **Special Rule:** In Bazaars/Caravan Rings, Broker DV −1. Exposing fraud without a Coin-Weigh Seal starts Exposure +1.

Faction	Aim	Strings
Coin-Weigh Tribunal (Tier crown)	Stabilize tariffs	Tariff Seals, Coin Scales, Audit Teams
Oasis Clans Compact (Tier city)	Protect wells	Water Shares, Caravan Well Rights, Desert Guides
Foreign Factors' League (Tier guild)	Preferential duties	Warehousing, Bonded Guards, Letters of Credit
Sand-Road Brotherhood (Tier street→guild)	Own the under-arcades	Contraband Vaults, Night Porters, False Seals

Adventure Starters: Missing Water Share deeds flood the market • Steppe Rangers feud spills into the Violet Bazaar • A cursed dye caravan seeks sanctuary under the Satrap Gardens.

7.2 Ecktoria – Marble & Fire

Districts: Grand Forum; Aqueduct Heights; Legion Quarter; Foundries; Riverside Tenements; Consecrated Courts. **Special Rule:** Any Expose of water theft is public: on hit, Mandate +1; on miss, Exposure +1 (panic).

Faction		Aim	Strings
Exarchate (Tier crown)		Rebalance old grants	Audit Writs, Tax Ledgers, Censures
Legions Remnant (Tier city)		Restore stipends	Veteran Rolls, Ar- mory Keys, Drill Grounds
Merchant Courts (Tier guild)		Secure monopolies	Guild Charters, Bridge Tolls, Import Licenses
Sun-Temple Synod (Tier synod)		Purify rites	Sanctuary, Proces- sion Routes, Oath Tablets

Adventure Starters: A lost aqueduct patent resurfaces • Legions demand arrears from the treasury • A relic procession goes off-script into riot.

7.3 Silkstrand – City of Bridges

Districts: Bridges & Canals; Dye Yards; Archivolt; Playhouse Row; Pilots’ Quays; Sestiere Courts.

Special Rule: In fog, Chase (boat/rooftop) DV –1 but Expose Position –1; a hit satire can create Audience tags citywide.

Faction		Aim	Strings
Dye Syndicate (Tier guild)		Maintain pigment monopoly	Vat Houses, Guild Scales, Apprentice Oaths
Bridge-Lords (Tier city)		Rule crossings	Toll Chains, Bridge Charters, Night Keys
Riverine Patrol (Tier city)		Curb smuggling	Patrol Boats, Fog Bells, Harbor War- rants
Playhouse Mum- mers (Tier street→guild)		Public favor	Masque Licenses, Satire Broadsheets, Crowd Hooks

Adventure Starters: A satire names names • The Night Keys list leaks • A foreign pigment line undercuts the vats.

7.4 Thepyrgos – Synod & Collegium

Districts: Synod Hill; Collegium of Keys; Harbor Quarter; Law Courts; Pilgrims’ Steps; Scriptorium Lanes. **Special Rule:** Begin with rites: Broker starts Dominant; breaking rites adds Exposure +1.

Faction		Aim	Strings
Archons' (Tier crown)	Synod	Codify chapterhouse votes	Writs of Law, Censure, Clerks
Collegium (Tier synod)		Protect privileges	Oath Registry, Sealed Stacks, Licentiae
Harbor (Tier guild)	Guild	Tariffs/pilots	Pilot Licenses, Quay Masters, Lantern-Law
Ember-Temple (Tier synod)		Zeal/charity	Processions, Sanctuary, Inquisitors

Adventure Starters: Charter revision threatens the Collegium • Temple schism spills into streets
 • A curse knits into tithe ledgers.

7.5 Zakov – Iron Haven (Freeport)

Lore: Zakov sits at the mouth of the Iron River, a lawless port ruled by the "Code of the Iron Trident." Ship captains hold sovereign authority over their vessels. The city is divided into Holds claimed by corsair fleets, merchant houses, and criminal syndicates. The Harbor Master's Court maintains navigation and collects the "Iron Tithe."

Districts: Ironworks; Salt Quarter; Smugglers' Cut; Old Citadel; Copper Market; Blackwater Quays. **Special Rule:** Ships flying no nation's colors are neutral. Smuggle starts Dominant; Expose a pirate's identity starts Desperate.

Faction		Aim	Strings
Ironmasters (Tier guild)		Secure raw ore/export tithes	Foundry Licenses, Ore Contracts, Bonded Guards
Corsair public (Tier street→guild)	Re-	Maintain maritime law/territory	Ship Papers, Privateer Charters, Harbor Rights
Harbor Master's Court (Tier city)		Keep harbor navigable/profitable	Navigation Marks, Docking Rights, Iron Tithe
Salt Guild (Tier guild)		Control salt trade/preservation	Salt Licenses, Preservation Contracts, Trade Routes

Adventure Starters: A rival fleet's flagship appears with no crew • The Iron Tithe ledgers show impossible debts • A ghost ship is sinking legitimate vessels • The Harbor Master's Court declares martial law.

8) PLAYER-FACING OPTIONS (LIGHT)

Urban Talents: Streetwise, Ledger-Eye, Bridge-Runner, Rite-Speaker, Patrol-Friend, Crowd-Reader, Shipwright, Corsair, Harbor Pilot, Salt-Trader.

Background Hooks: Guild-taught, Pilot's Kin, Temple Page, Festival Barker, Caravan Clerk, Exarchate Apprentice, Ship's Boy, Corsair Captain, Harbor Guard, Salt Miner, River Runner, Dock Master.

Temptations (optional): Replace vice with Ambition / Comfort / Fury / Pride. Track a 4-segment Temptation Timer that the GM can press in districts tagged with that flavor; spend Boons to resist or clear.

9) GM TOOLKIT

5-Minute City Prep

1. Pick 1 City Kit
2. Circle 4 Factions
3. Highlight 2 Districts for the scene
4. Note the Special Rule
5. Draw 1 Urban Deck card
6. Ready for first scene

Default Ripples (Success / Failure)

- **Success:** ally Influence +1 (or +2 if on Aim); enemy Exposure +1; clean win reduces ally Exposure -1.
- **Failure:** enemy Influence +1 (or +2 on Aim); ally Exposure +1; internal failure also Stability +1.

DV Cheatsheet

- Petition: 2-4 (temple/court)
- Broker: 3-4 (neutral ground helps)
- Expose: 3-5 (proof lowers)
- Infiltrate: 3-5 (wards raise)

Three-Timer Rule

Only maintain three active timers at once: 1. Situation Timer (the current scene's main tension) 2. Counter-Timer (opposition or environment) 3. Campaign Timer (faction agenda or long-term threat) Merge or retire others.

10) PRINTABLE AIDS

- City Sheet (template)
 - District Cards (tags/effects)
 - Factions & Strings minis
 - Urban Deck prompts (52-card list)
 - Chase Ladders sidecard
 - Events & Omens mini-table
 - Investigation Tracker
 - Relationship Map Template
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CHANGELOG

v1.0 – Final revision aligned with core Fate's Edge rules. - Streamlined district effects; added district complication timers. - Standardized faction timers (Influence/Agenda [6]). - Merged String Cutting into core Assets/Timers. - Added explicit Investigation Timer progression. - Reformatted lists as tables for readability. - Expanded Zakov lore and special rules. - Reinforced Three-Timer Rule and 5-Minute Prep.

End of v1.0